

Keep it Updated

When the Windows 95 TCP/IP stack was updated, not many people knew about it. Those who didn't update their operating systems faced a lot of problems with dial-up connections. Earlier, when anti-virus software did not have automatic update features, the software would become useless in just a fortnight. Users were ignorant about these updates and eventually faced several virus attacks. Now newsletters let you know of various critical updates. Oracle charges heavily for every update to their database software—one can even buy an annual Updates Subscription Service contract from them.



UpdateExpert manages updates and patches across machines on a network

Look before you update

Not all updates are helpful and some fixes bring with it a dozen other bugs. As a standard practice to read the release notes thoroughly and find out what exactly the patch mends. Many security vulnerabilities arise only under certain conditions, which may not be applicable to your computer.

You can easily evolve a quick and easy method for taking critical backups. A snapshot of the registry can restore Windows to a healthy state when something goes wrong. Windows 98 automatically takes backups of the registry and Windows Me creates Restore Points,

by which you can roll back the complete system to any previous restore point. Sometimes system-critical files get overwritten with newer files, like when updating hardware drivers. In such a case, just a registry backup may not help. It's a good idea to clone your entire Windows installation regularly using a cloning software such as Norton

Ghost (www.symantec.com). Should the update cause problems, you can roll back to the last clone instead of reinstalling Windows.

Don't jump at updates unless they address an extremely critical, high-risk security issue. Always wait for a couple of days and let some experts try them out first. They can point out the importance of the patch, as well as potential problems with the patch itself. The experts may also be able to guide you to work around the problem without using the patch or fixing the problems that the patch brings with it. 

VEER KOTHARI